



Five Faces of Mother India

Written by
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Illustrated by
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Original Story in Urdu '**Bharat Mata ke Paanch Roop**' by Khwaja Ahmad Abbas

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'**Five Faces of Mother India**' — English Translation by Syeda Hameed

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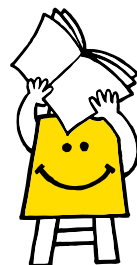
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Remembering the legendary Khwaja Ahmad Abbas

An introduction by Syeda Hameed

Most people would remember Khwaja Ahmad Abbas in connection with Raj Kapoor's box office hits such as *Awara*, *Shri 420*, *Mera Naam Joker* and *Bobby*. Abbas wrote the stories, dialogues, and screenplays of all these films. Whenever Abbas wrote the story for Raj Kapoor, the film became a hit. And whenever Abbas wrote a story to be produced and directed by himself, the film flopped. Abbas gave Raj the idea for the song, *Mera Joota hai japani, ye patloon inglistani, sar par laal topi rusi, phir bhi dil hai hindustani*, and in Mukesh's voice the song resounded through the world. The same global fame was achieved by another song, *Awara Hoon* and that was his idea too. But in his own film *Saat Hindustani* when Abbas introduced a ghazal written by the great poet Kaifi Azmi in the voice of the legendary Mukesh, the film flopped.

*Iss tarah jum me toofan mein rakhkho qadam
Ke qadam choomney ko kinara badhey
(Step firmly in the raging storm so that
The shore itself moves close to kiss your feet)*

The film flopped, the song flopped but its star Amitabh Bachchan became a millennium star!

This is the story of Abbas's success and Abbas's failure.



At the age of seven, he sent his first story to the children's magazine, *Phool* which was immediately published to much acclaim. Once the boy's pen began moving there was no stopping it. It was in the same year that he sat in a small cinema hall and watched his first Charlie Chaplin film. The intense desire to make films began to stir his mind. This desire sunk its first root in Bombay (now Mumbai) when he wrote a story for Bombay Talkies, *Naya Sansar*.

This process, once started, continued all his life. He wrote his column *Last Page* for the weekly magazine *Blitz*, for an uninterrupted period of 45 years. The same column appeared in *Azad Qalam* in Urdu and in *Hindi Blitz*. He wrote 74 books during his lifespan of 73 years. The year 2014 was Khwaja Ahmad Abbas's centenary year. The country remembered Abbas. Amitabh Bachchan called him 'The man who saw tomorrow'.

Now we come to an amazing story which Abbas wrote with his heart's blood, *Bharat Mata ke Paanch Roop*. In its preface Abbas defines the word 'mother'. He writes, 'The relation between mother and child defies definition. When something is very dear to us we always club it with the word 'mother'. We call our *watan* Motherland. Our earth which feeds the entire human race we call *Dharti Mata*.

We Indians always refer to our country as *Bharat Mata*, our slogan is *Bharat Mata ki Jai!* Our other epithet is *Vande Mataram*, meaning Hail Mother.'



Abbas asks, 'Who is *Bharat Mata*? Is she a deity from heaven whom the gods have sent to look after our country? Is she a Maharani wrapped in silks, laden with gold jewellery such as we see in Hindi films?'

Nehru writes in his book, *Discovery of India*, 'Once I asked a group of peasants what they thought was *Bharat Mata*. They told me, "It is this very earth, which gives us birth and nourishment; for us this is the face of Mother India".'

Abbas writes, 'When I raise the slogan ***'Bharat Mata ki Jai'***, a few faces of ordinary women rise up in my mind. They are all unknown to the world. Leave alone their pictures, even their names have never hit any news media. Yet, each one of them deserves the epithet, Mother India.'

The first of these women is an old weaver from Panipat, who people called Hakko. Inspired by Mahatma Gandhi, she began spending all her time at the spinning wheel and became an epitome of generosity.

The second mother is a Saraswat Brahmin from Pune. Abbas writes, 'Nani has never read a newspaper, listened to radio news or attended a single political gathering. She has never raised the slogan of ***Inquilab Zindabad***. But Inquilab itself came looking for her in the narrow lanes of Pune'. How did this happen? You will have to read the story to find this out.

The third Mother is a Brahmin from Tamil Nadu in whose house one sees the entire diversity of India. Abbas writes, 'This is an interesting image of ***Bharat Mata***. In her one hand is a book, in the other a fan, a rose in her hair, the magic of Bengal in her eyes, and in her heart the zest and 'wickedness' of youth.'

The fourth mother is a Sardarni from Rawalpindi. In August- September 1947, when a massive storm tossed millions of human beings, like dried leaves, from one end of the country to another, this mother (known as Ma Ji) kept her heart free of any bitterness or anger. Abbas writes, 'In the heart of this ***sharanarthi Bharat Mata*** there was no rage, only memories of the watan she left behind; memories which are as fragrant as its peaches and as soft as its pears.'

The fifth is the author's own mother who was wrenched out of her beloved Panipat. India was divided, and people of Panipat perforce sent to the other side. After every namaz, she raised her hands in prayer. 'Allah, may all Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs return to their homes. And by the grace of their return may we also have the fortune to return to our Panipat.'

What were the common values that Abbas saw in all these women? A deep love for all humanity in their hearts! With the exception of one, all mothers had a minimum of education, but their life's philosophy was deeper than that of many world renowned scholars. They all loved their country but this love rose above country to embrace all humanity. All five had known intense pain but it had not resulted in bitterness or hardness of temperament. This is the real face of Bharat Mata.

Why did Khwaja Ahmad Abbas write about these five Bharat Matas? In his films, novels and writings runs his progressive philosophy. He always understood the importance of humanism, brotherhood and egalitarianism. His films might not have been 'hits' at the box office but to this day he is considered the touchstone of progressive thinking.



From these stories, one also learns about his insight into history. History is not the story of kings and princes. Ordinary lives have as much place in history as the stories of leaders and founders. The stories of these women are lessons from Abbas that each individual has his or her own place and significance in the universe.

With these thoughts, the writer gifted ***The Five Faces of Bharat Mata*** to the children of this world. With the magic of his pen, he makes each Bharat Mata stand alive before you. Their human values become so intense that you feel the meaninglessness of caste, creed, gender and class. This gift of KA Abbas is enough to take this generation on the trajectory of an open mind and an open heart.



The Shroud

It happened thirty years ago when I was a small boy. In my neighbourhood there lived a weaver; she was old and very poor. Her name was Hakeemat but everyone called her Hakko. She may have been sixty years old at that time. She had been widowed at a young age and all her life she had toiled with her two hands to bring up her children. Even in her old age she woke up before sunrise. Summer or winter, when we were snuggled in our *razais* we heard the sound of the *chakki** from her house. She swept the floors, spun the *charkha*, wove cloth, cooked and washed her children's clothes and those of her grandchildren and great grandchildren. Hers was a tiny house.

**chakki* – Grinding stone.

Compared to ours with its huge courtyard, it was like a shoe-box. Two small rooms, one narrow *daalaan** and a very small courtyard. But she used to keep it so shining clean that people said one could eat puffed rice off Hakko's floor.

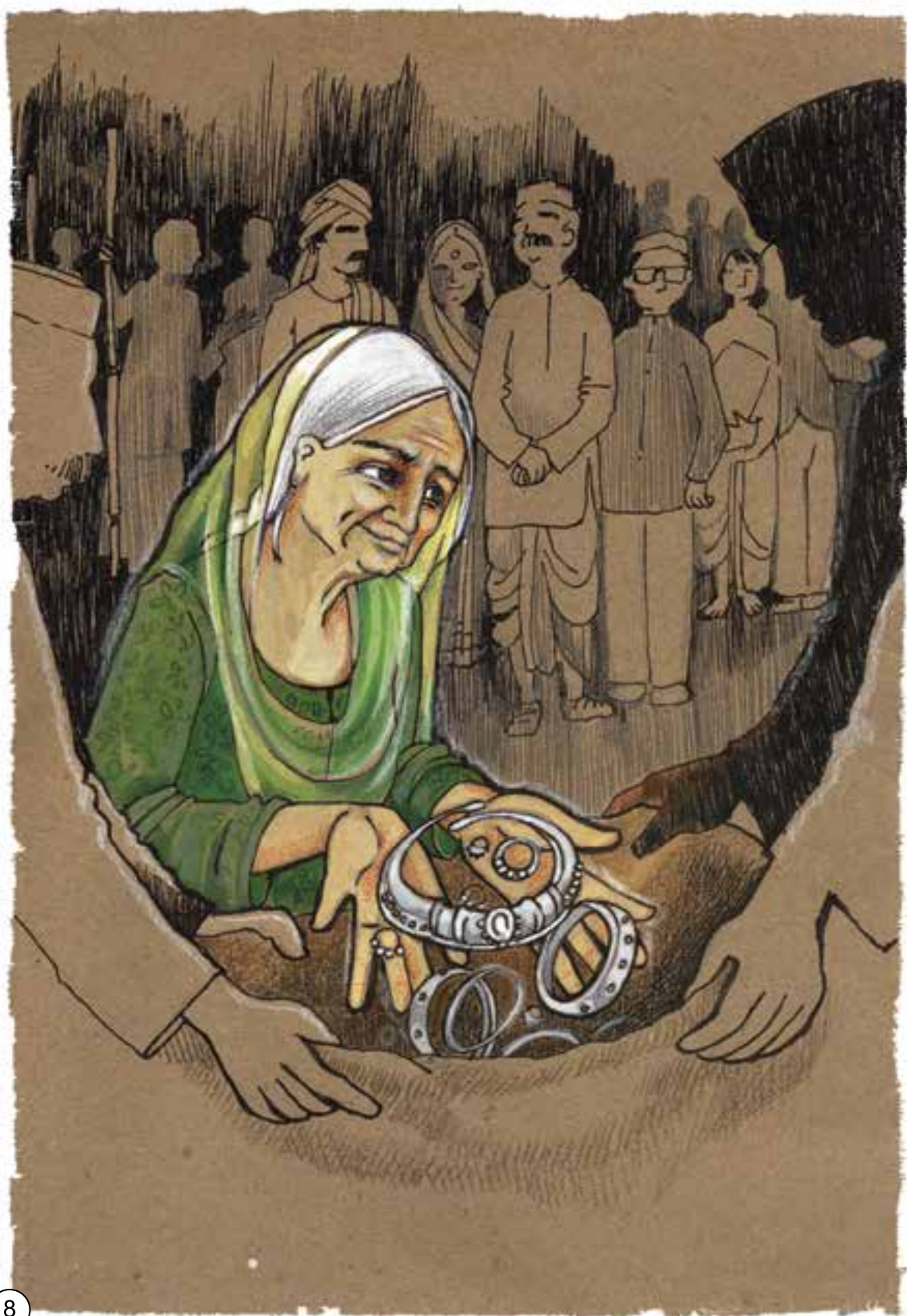
Hakko worked from morning till evening. Yet whenever she came to our house she was always cheerful. I still recall her face. Dark skinned, over which her white shock of hair looked very nice. She had a strong frame. Until her last day, her back was erect. Towards the end of her life she had lost a few teeth which made her lisp. But she was a fine raconteur.

We children hovered around her and she told us stories about the three princes, eight princesses, about fairies and ogres and jinns. She did not observe *purdah**. She ran her weaving business



**daalaan* - Open area in front of a house, usually surrounded by boundary walls.

**purdah* - Literally means 'curtain'. It is also a custom where women and girls from some communities cover themselves fully to stay away from the public gaze.



by herself. She was illiterate and had probably never heard about the concept of gender equality. She knew nothing about democracy and socialism. But she herself was never dominated by any man, nor was she overawed by the rich, the affluent, or any person of authority.

Hakko had worked all her life to save a little money for her children. She had never heard the word 'bank'. All her life's savings, which may have been 100-200 rupees, were in the form of a few silver ornaments around her neck and wrists. I can still recall how her ears looked, loaded down with silver earrings. She held them very dear because they were her insurance for her old age. One day her neighbours noticed that her earrings and the *hansli** around her neck were missing. But a smile still danced on her face, and her back had not the slightest stoop!

It so happened that one day, Gandhiji and his fellow freedom fighters, the Ali brothers, had come to our *mohalla**. They made speeches in our Nana's house about non-cooperation

**hansli* – A traditional, solid necklace that looks like a big bracelet, usually made in brass or silver.

**mohalla* – A small neighbourhood.

and self-governance. Hakko sat in a corner, listening to them. Afterwards, when the contribution tray was passed around, Hakko took off her ornaments and dropped them into the tray. Following her other women in the gathering also dropped their jewellery into the tray.

From that day onwards Hakko became what was called a *khilafati**. She used to come to our house and ask Nana for news, often asking, "When will this British rule end?" She went to the *Khilafat* and Congress gatherings with great interest and tried to understand the political scene. But a lifetime of hard work had taken a toll on her body. First, her eyesight failed her, and then her hands and feet. Hakko became house-bound.

**khilafat* - A revolution which goes against the existing system in order to make it better for people. A khilafati is such a revolutionary.



But she never stopped spinning at the *charkha*. Long hours of practice enabled her to weave with the help of touch rather than sight. When her grandchildren tried to stop her, she simply said, "I am weaving cloth for my shroud."

Then she died. Hakko's last wish was this: "Bury me in the *khaddar kafan** which I have woven. If you bury me in English cloth, my spirit will never be at peace."

In those days *kafans* were made from English *Laththa** cloth. Hakko was the only one then to be covered by a *khaddar kafan*. When her *Janaza** was carried to the cemetery there were a few relatives, some neighbours; no procession, no flowers or flags. Just a *khaddar kafan*.

Alas! Had I understood the worth and depth of Hakko, I would at least have shouted one slogan, *Bharat Mata ki Jai!*

**kafan* - A shroud, a piece of white cloth in which dead bodies are wrapped before the final rites according to the Islamic faith.

**laththa* - A coarse cloth woven using short span cotton on a hand loom.

**janaza* - A procession of people taking a dead person for the final rites according to the Islamic faith.



Long live Manu Maharaj!

Manu Maharaj divided humanity into four classes. Brahmins, who were born from the mouth of Brahma; Kshatriyas, who came from Brahma's hands; Vaish, who came from his legs; and Sudras, who came from his feet. The latter were always trampled beneath the feet of upper castes. Apart from these four classes, and considered more 'polluted' even than the Sudras were the Malechh, those who believed in other faiths and for whom there was no space in Manu Maharaj's society or *samaj*.

During Manu's days, this division was useful to maintain social order. To keep intact the Hindu samaj, it was important to create hatred and repugnance for the external invader. Over thousands of years of human evolution, this caste hierarchy became

increasingly rigid. Society kept changing. Human beings evolved from being hunter-gatherers to agriculturalists, to settlers, to landlords, to rulers, to conquerors, to democrats. One period dovetailed into the next. But the stranglehold of caste was always maintained, and to a great extent, is maintained even today.

Bharat Mata, who is everyone's mother, does she believe in caste and class distinctions among her children? Does she discriminate

between Brahmin and Sudra, Hindu and Muslim? Probably not, because she loves all her children equally; dark or fair, pretty or plain, bright or dull.

Some think Bharat Mata is illiterate, old fashioned, in fact, downright retrograde. Then how is it possible

for her to leave the path of Manu Maharaj and adopt the path of equity

and justice? When I think about all this I recall the grandmother of my friend who lives in Pune. This eighty year old Brahmin woman had seen many ups and downs in life. But her age-lined face had a strange peace, as if she has fathomed the mystery of life's end. For many years she had lived a solitary life looking after



her children and grandchildren. She no longer had the energy of her youth but she was the one in the house who woke up the earliest. She began her day with a cold water bath followed by the daily prayer.

Nani could only speak in Marathi. During her time, girls were not taught to read or write. She had never read a newspaper, nor listened to the radio, nor listened to political speeches at rallies. She had never ever raised the slogan of *Inquilab Zindabad**. But it was *inquilab* itself which came looking for her in the narrow lanes of Pune and found her in her own house.

It so happened that in 1947, her grandson, along with some friends, joined the freedom movement. Suddenly Nani's small house which for centuries had resonated only with sounds of *bhajans*, became vibrant with passionate whispers of young underground revolutionaries. New words and thoughts began to find their way into Nani's ears. Freedom, Revolution, Resistance, Self Governance, Swaraj, Democracy.

**Inquilab Zindabad* - This was one of the most famous slogans during our struggle for freedom, and means 'Hail revolution'.

Nani's house was located in a narrow lane, and therefore, most appropriate for political activity. Many revolutionaries began to camp there. These were youth who had several names but who had no caste. Their only 'caste' was that they belonged to the Inquilab brotherhood. They arrived at the dead of night and left before dawn. A few used to huddle together in the room upstairs to escape the police. Nani looked after them in the same manner as she looked after her grandchildren. She used to make tea, cook food, provide bedding and after performing pooja, prayed for their safety. In her untutored mind the thought had taken root that these young men, who held their lives literally in their palms, were struggling for the freedom of their country.

Nani may have been illiterate but she was no fool. She spoke little but listened intently, and she thought a lot. Very soon she found out that not all her grandson's friends were Brahmins. There were many of lower castes. Some of them were Sudras and some were Muslims. But for some reason Nani did not observe any untouchability, or *chhoot chhaat* as she called it, with them. What was it that gave her the strength to break the rules of Manu Maharaj? When the boys fell asleep Nani kept her

ear to the ground for the sound of the police so she could warn the boys. And one day, that is what happened. The police saw their opportunity during a dark night to pounce on the group. Everyone was asleep. The only one awake was Nani. She saw a police van stop in her narrow lane. Immediately, she woke up her grandson and his companions.

Before the police could enter their house, the boys jumped to the roof of the next house. House after house, roof after roof they jumped and ran and were able to get out of the danger zone. When the police searched the house they found none but an old, half-blind, toothless Nani. What they also found were blankets and beds laid out on the floor. They took Nani to the police station. Alas! She had to bear this ignominy in her old age. For hours they questioned her. "Who were the people staying in your house? What did they talk about? Where is your grandson? Where are his companions?"

To all their questions she had only one innocent answer. "I don't know. An illiterate old woman, what do I know!" Fed up of her only answer, they let her go. Not one word had escaped her lips which could give them a clue to the whereabouts of *Inquilabis*.



Nani's pooja still goes on but she has stopped observing *chhoot chhaat*. Last year when I went to her grandson's wedding, there



were other Muslim guests who were staying at her house and taking part in the ceremonies. Some bigoted relatives refused to attend the wedding. They coaxed Nani to exert her seniority and ask her grandson to stop the Malechh from taking part.

But Nani turned a deaf ear to their pleas. On the morning of the wedding, I saw Nani giving tea to my wife. And Nani talked to her too, with some help from her granddaughter who acted as the translator. She was talking about the same things that my grandmother used to talk about, and in much the same manner as my grandmother did.

From that day onwards, I often wonder whether when the history of our freedom movement is written will it have the name of that unknown Nani who for the sake of our freedom

gave up her age-old prejudices and loosened the bonds of tradition. And then I wonder what was the power in this old, thin, half-blind, toothless woman that she was unafraid to confront the might of Manu Maharaj. Was it because she was Bharat Mata? And is it that Bharat Mata is far stronger and immortal in comparison to *Manu Smriti*?



Beauty in diversity

We, who live in the North, carry many prejudices against those who live in South India. For example, we believe that all those who live in the South are 'Madrasis' and speak the 'Madrasi' language. We believe that they practise strict untouchability; even if the shadow of an untouchable falls on them, he is beaten up and the Brahmin has to perform total ablutions.

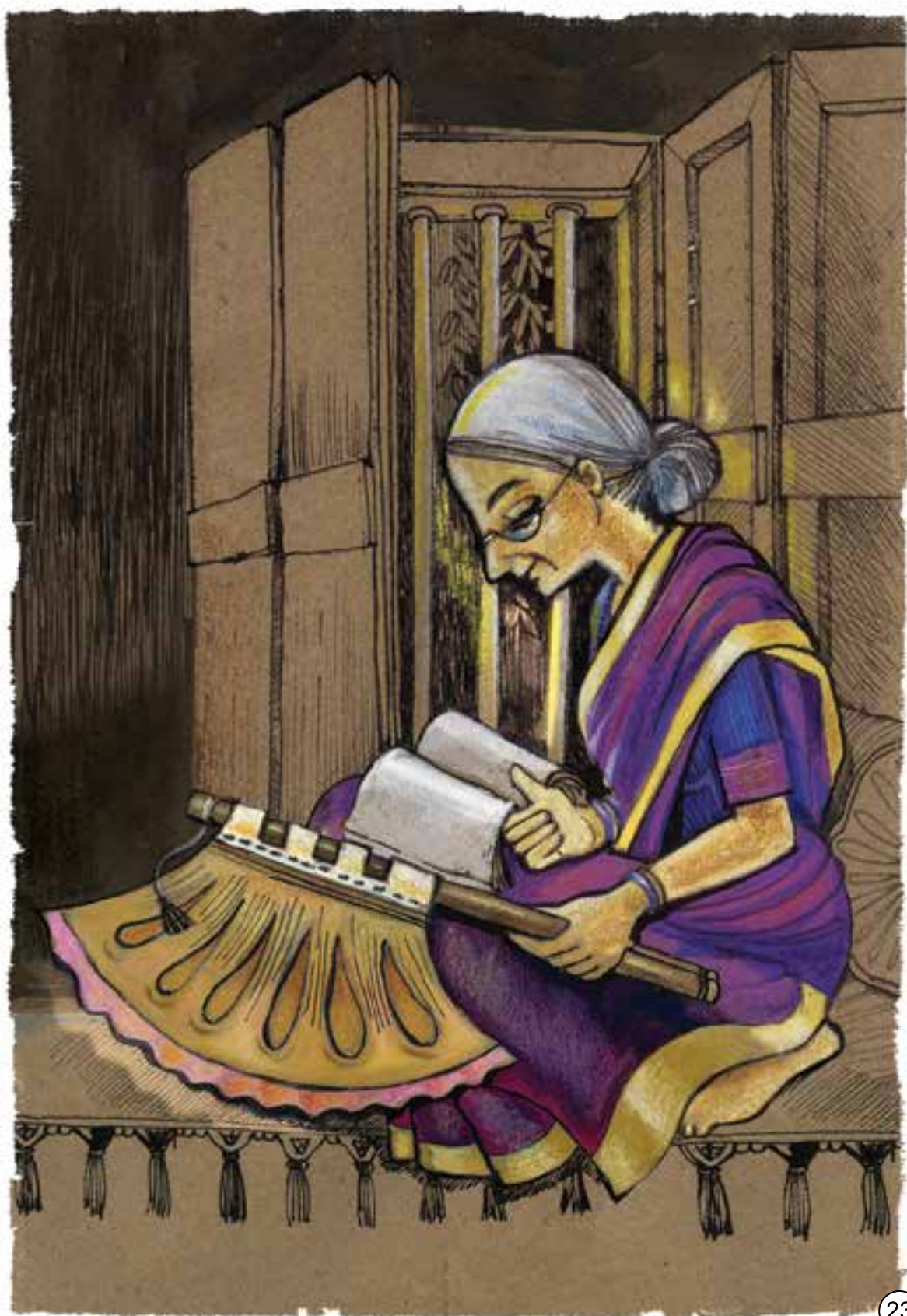
You can imagine my amazement when we reached Madras and my friend said to my wife and me, "You are having lunch at my house." I knew that my friend despite being a Brahmin did not believe in caste. But his parents? Specially his mother? Would she tolerate two Malechh eating in her house? Then we assumed that they would feed us, outside the kitchen. Filled with these thoughts, we reached the house where his mother and two sisters lived. My wife was apprehensive about the treatment from these staunch 'Madrasi' Brahmins. But we were received with such warmth that the moment we entered we forgot all our doubts and fears.

We stayed in Madras for ten days and ate both our meals in that Brahmin household. This was not a western setting where meals were served on the dining table. We sat on the floor and ate on banana leaves or in brass *thalis*. During all these days we did not experience the slightest difference in the way we were treated, and nor was there any *chhoot chhaat*. We could go into the kitchen and the *chauka* or cooking area. My friend's mother told everyone that my wife was her own daughter. In those few days it felt like we were one family.

How did this traditional family acquire its liberal outlook? My friend's father had an old connection with Gandhiji. Twenty years ago he had given up a lucrative job to work with Gandhiji on social upliftment. Since then, this family had been part of the national movement. But their liberal outlook was not confined only to the national movement. In the last thirty years, they had lived in Delhi, Calcutta, Jamshedpur, Allahabad, Wardha, Almora, Bombay and who knows where else. Their mother tongue was Tamil but their Ma lived in Malabar during her childhood. She spoke fluent Malayalam. Many years in Uttar Pradesh had taught them perfect Hindustani. Bengali they spoke exactly as native Bengalis because one daughter was

married to a Bengali film director and the other to a Bengali journalist. The grandsons who lived in Bombay spoke a medley of Tamil, Bengali, Hindustani, Gujarati, Marathi and English. And the food cooked in the house was anyway *panchmel*, or a medley of cuisines. This household could certainly claim, "We are Hindi and our country is Hindustan."

The most important and interesting member of this household was the mother. This woman who must have been a beauty thirty years ago, received a college education. She not only spoke but read and wrote English. She wrote poetry and prose in Tamil. She had sent her daughters and sons for higher education. Her husband had earned 1800 rupees a month and she had lived in a grand house. She had always travelled first class. Today, she lived with her family in one room. She wore khaddar saris and broken chappals. She cooked for the entire family and only after she had fed the children and guests would she sit down to eat herself. Immersing herself in domestic work had not shut the windows of her mind. She continued to read Tamil and Hindi books and journals. On national and international issues, she had an opinion and engaged in



discussions. She participated in political and literary gatherings. Deeply interested in art and music, she had arranged for her girls to learn music and dancing. She watched films and was a keen critic of their quality.

To serve their country, both husband and wife gave up a life of comfort. But there was no bitterness or arrogance which was sometimes seen in ardent patriots as if to announce their sacrifice and renunciation. Her husband, son and she herself had been in prison. But she made little of her jail *yatra*. Despite very modest means, she was cheerful. She was often seen breaking into peals of laughter, while remaining involved in all aspects of life. She was almost 60 years old, hair turning grey, wrinkles showing, but her heart remained young. The world had not robbed her of her winning smile, which was her most attractive feature.

I recall one afternoon we were all asleep on the floor. It was summer. I woke up and saw her wearing spectacles, immersed in reading a Tamil book. At the same time, she was gently fanning us with her hand fan. On her face were beads of sweat. Her mind was on the book and her heart, with her children.

She was paying no attention to herself. I knew she would get up any minute and make tea for us. Then she would bathe the little ones. I was very surprised at the amount of work she did without a single frown. How was she, who once led a life of luxury, happily living in this reduced state? How could she read and fan us at the same time? How could she cook and simultaneously argue about politics?

Suddenly a thought occurred to me: this is another interesting persona of Bharat Mata. In one hand, she holds a book and in the other, a fan. In her hair is a rose and at her feet, the dust of daily work. Her eyes have the magic of Bengal and her lips the smile of Malabar. In her body, you find the grace of Rajasthan, and the vigour of Punjab. On her face, there is the sobriety of age and in her heart the fun and vigour of youth. She is Bharat Mata!



Refugee

The catastrophic events of August 1947 blew one crore human beings like dried leaves from one end of the subcontinent to another. People from Peshawar to Bombay (now Mumbai), people from Delhi had to move to Karachi, and the people of Lyallpur, to Panipat. Lifelong friends and neighbours were separated. Brother was separated from brother, people ejected from their homes. Kings became paupers and sheltered women came to be sold in bazaars of flesh.

This storm uprooted two old women from their ancient homeland or *watan* and threw them thousands of miles away into Bombay. One of them was my mother and the other was the mother of my Sikh friend. One was from West Punjab the other from East Punjab. One came from Rawalpindi, the other from Panipat and both reached Bombay on the same day.

My mother left Panipat at the dead of night for Delhi. Here she stayed for three weeks in one room where families of other relatives had taken refuge. Then along with sons, grandsons and granddaughters, she arrived in Bombay by air.

I called my mother Amma, and my friend called his mother Ma ji. When they came here, I realized that this was in fact the only difference between them.

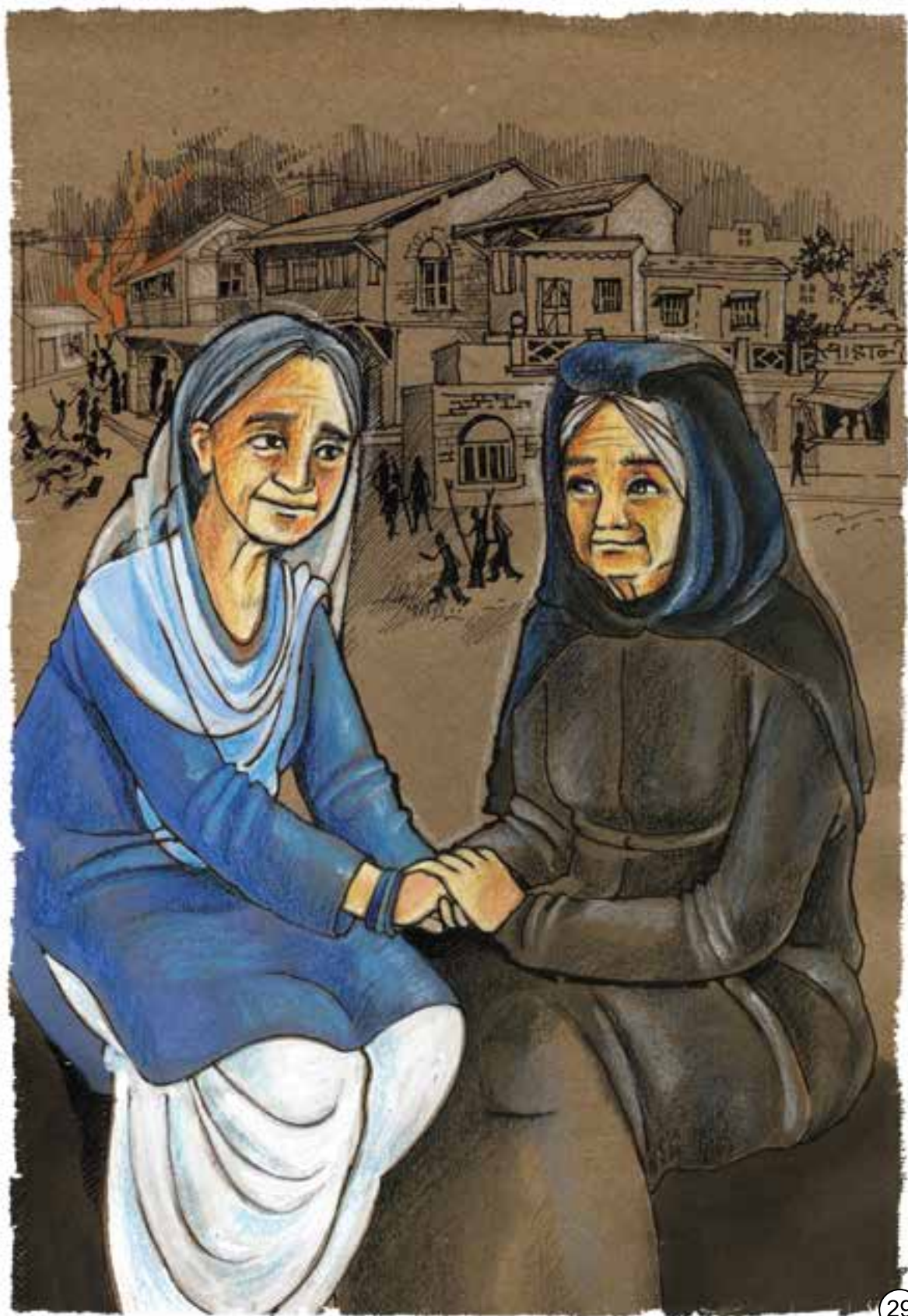
Ma ji used to live in her own house in Rawalpindi. They had rented the shops below their living quarters. Their tenants were mostly Muslims, in fact the entire *mohalla* was Muslim. Sardarji and Ma ji were very popular among the neighbours. For generations the families had been friends. In weddings and funerals they met; Muslim women called her Behnji and their daughters referred to her as Ma ji.

Rawalpindi was Ma ji's world. She never went anywhere else. Her son worked in Lahore, then Calcutta (now Kolkata) and later in Bombay. But for Ma ji, these cities were another world. If she had her way, she would have never let the son go anywhere and kept him close to her in Rawalpindi. She often thought,

'What is the point of earning money when he neither gets pure ghee to eat nor pure milk to drink there? Neither peaches nor pears, apples or grapes!' At home, the cattle gave ten solid *seers* of milk daily. After churning the milk, butter was produced and the whey was distributed to all the neighborhood. All who received it gave her their blessings. She became sad thinking of her son. Who knew whether he got proper food in Bombay!

Near Rawalpindi was their ancestral land. During the harvest there was enough grain from the field. Milk, curd and ghee they produced at home. Their son also sent money. That was enough for a decent life.

In June, when she heard the news of the partition and the creation of India and Pakistan, Ma ji was not perturbed in the least. She had no use for political wrangles. Whether India or Pakistan, her concern was for her neighbours. They had always maintained excellent relations with them. Whenever communal outbursts occurred in the country, Ma ji and her family had always felt totally safe. But this time the fire was too intense. Sikhs and Hindus of Rawalpindi were sensing danger. Ma ji however felt no fear. Her son wrote, 'come immediately to Bombay' but she refused



to leave Rawalpindi. Many of her relatives and acquaintances went to East Punjab or Delhi but she did not budge. Whenever anyone pointed out the danger in Rawalpindi and advised her to go to India, her one reply was, "In this *mohalla* who will kill us? They are our own children who live all around us."

Then conditions became worse, after the arrival of Muslim refugees from East Punjab. Her own neighbours advised her to go to a safe place because they were fearful of her safety. Many of them still said, "Don't go, we will protect you with our lives." One Muslim tailor who was their longtime tenant and deeply devoted to them cried a lot and begged them not to go. Some of the people uprooted from Eastern Punjab were camped across the street from Ma ji. She could not bear to see their wretched condition; so utensils, blankets, mattresses were promptly sent. Not for a moment did she think that these were Muslims, enemies of Sikhs. Not for a moment did she think she should not help them, nor did she imagine that in a few days she would be in much the same state.

It was then that some marauders stabbed a Hindu *tangewala*. I have heard this story from Ma ji herself. "Beta! The *tangewala*



was a Hindu, no doubt, but the horse! It has no religion, no caste. But they did not spare even that mute animal. Jabbed it lifeless with their knives. The madness had gone to their heads. Like they were some other creatures, no longer human." After this incident she had to accept that it was no longer safe for her or her family to stay here.

So she left her Rawalpindi house with all her belongings and walked out only locking the front door. She thought, I am not leaving for ever, once this madness subsides we will return. But what her ancient eyes witnessed on the way to Delhi was enough to make the thought of return, near impossible. By the time she reached Bombay the very name of Rawalpindi had become a tug at her heart.

She used to live in a large six-room house in Rawalpindi. In Bombay, she and her husband lived with their son in one small room. The room was flanked on either side by a *dhobi-ghat* and a coal depot. Behind the room was a tiny space which served at once as kitchen, bathroom and store.

When my friend used to live here by himself, his room was a garbage dump with old newspapers, dirty dishes and unwashed clothes piled here and there. But now despite the tiny space, everything was neat, tidy and in place. White covers on the beds, the floor shining, not a spot of dust or dirt to be seen. For her husband and son, Ma ji cooked with her own hands. Never was a visitor allowed to leave before being served with some food. Ma ji had lost her house, her worldly possessions, and from a land owner she had become a refugee, but her hospitality remained unchanged.

Ma ji was fair complexioned and of short stature. Her hair had turned completely white from being black-and-white, in the short while since she left her Rawalpindi. She no longer kept well but continued to work endlessly. Whether cooking for her son, patching clothes for her husband, making tea or *lassi*

for her guests, she did the chores all by herself. Seeing her, no one would believe that she had seen terrible times and that she was a refugee. She never spoke ill of the Muslims on whose account she had become homeless. She spoke of her Muslim neighbours with great love. She dictated letters to them and felt very happy when she received their replies. When she met my mother for the first time, they embraced each other and were, for a few moments, lost in memories of their respective *watans*. Both old women cried silent tears. Then they tried to console one another as blood sisters. When I saw these two, one Sikh, the other Muslim crying over the other's sorrow, I felt that the hatred between the two communities, Sikh and Muslim, was being washed away by their tears.



Ma ji never made much of her sorrow or her losses. But sometimes she says with a sigh, "Your Bombay may be a big city, son. But we will never forget our Rawalpindi. Those peaches, those pears..." Then she becomes quiet and her sunken

eyes well up. It seems that in the heart of this Bharat Mata there is no room for anger or hatred. There are only memories of the past, linked to the land she left behind. Memories which are soft as pears and fragrant as peaches.



The End of Hatred

For every person his mother is the most dearly loved person. So if I include my own mother in this list, it should be no surprise. If there was any other in my place, he too would have brought his mother into the narrative. This is because the first glimpse we have of Bharat Mata is in our mother's face. And for each one of us, of all the forms of Bharat Mata, the dearest and most familiar is the form of our own mother.

So far as I am concerned I must say that it was in her last days that I realized the strength of her character, her humanism, and her acceptance. Until that time she was just my mother, but after the horrific events of 1947, for the first time I saw in my mother the grandeur of Bharat Mata.

When refugees from the devastated West Punjab arrived in Panipat and made it difficult for Muslims to remain there, they all began their *hejrat** to Pakistan. Our relatives began to put pressure on my mother to go with them; they also wrote to me asking me to come to Karachi from Bombay. She refused point blank. "I will not leave our home. My son has decided to stay in India and I am with him in this decision." She spent over twenty days in Panipat, while the riots were raging all around. Curfew was not lifted for seven days. For days, there was nothing to eat but roti and chutney. For days children got no milk. And *paan*, which was my mother's addiction, began to be sold at a rupee per leaf. It was torn into ten small pieces and made to last the whole day. No male member of the family was in Panipat at the time. I was in Bombay, my one brother in Pune, the other in Delhi. Those days, even a short distance of 50 miles from Delhi to Panipat, was difficult to cover.

The responsibility of the entire family in Panipat was my mother's. Letters and telegrams could not go back and forth.

**hejrat* - Mass movement of people leaving from one place to another.



She had no news of us, nor we of her. Despite that Amma remained unwavering in her decision to stay in India.

Then one night, a military truck arrived from Delhi to transport those of our relatives who had decided to stay in India. All they got was one hour to pack their belongings. Whatever the burqa-clad women could, they picked up in a hurry themselves and walked out of the house. At the time my mother did not for a moment think that she was leaving her home and her *watan* for ever. She was sure that when matters improved, she would

return to Panipat. She locked the front door and pasted a notice, 'Residents of this house are not going to Pakistan. They are going to see their relatives in Bombay. They will continue to live in India.'

For twenty days they stayed in Delhi. Thirty people in one room. It was impossible to reach the airport, and trains were hardly running. Here they got news that our houses in Panipat were looted and refugees had occupied them.

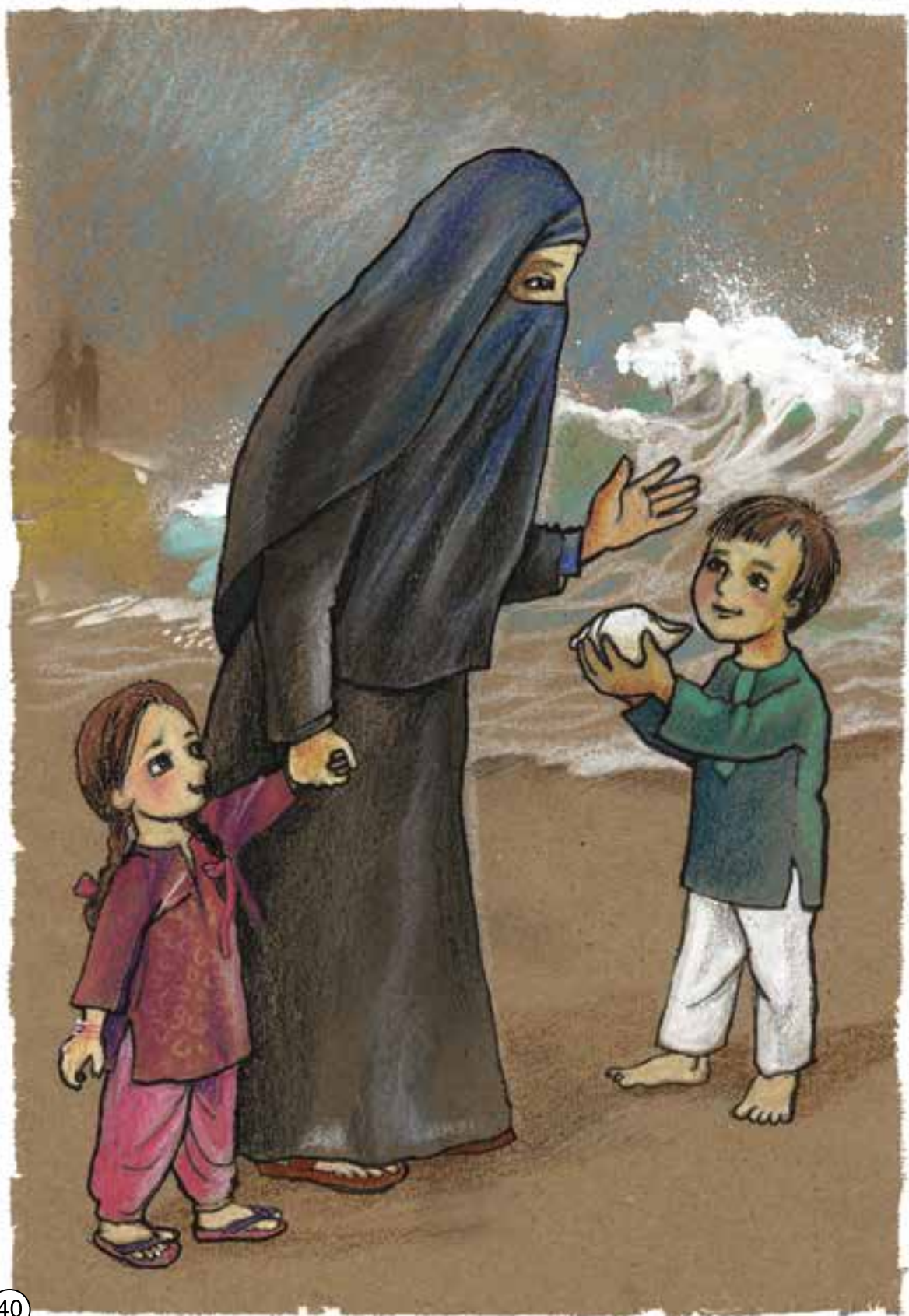
Fear for their life, lack of food and being cooped in a single room, made their faces deathly pale. Children became emaciated. At last the flights became operational and for the first time in her life, my mother travelled without her *burqa*. The night before she was to land in Bombay, I kept awake. I was thinking about what all these events would have done to my mother. Would she have been swept away with this tornado of hate, revenge, and crimes in the name of religion? This tornado which was raging in Pakistan and India, what would it do to her? Would her lifelong creed of justice, compassion, equity be drowned in this sea of human blood? Would her naturally cheerful and lively temperament become victim to this mounting despair?

I knew well the state of her health. She had suffered from asthma for the last nearly twenty years. Hysteria had been her lifelong companion. The untimely death of her husband and daughter had dealt her the sharpest blow. At sixty she looked like she was eighty, so depleted was her energy. She needed help to walk a few steps. Would she be able to stay alive after all this suffering? And air travel? What would it do to her?

Until the plane landed, I was plagued with these thoughts. Then I saw her! Wrapped in a *chador**, not in a *burqa*, she was coming down the stairs with the help of her daughter. I felt tears sting my eyes when I thought of how particular she was about her *burqa*. She who had had fierce arguments with me on this matter had to give up her *burqa* to save her life.

All my life I had tried to get her to give up the *burqa*. But at that moment, seeing her without it, did not make me happy. I was afraid this helplessness would make her bitter and cynical. Would she curse the world and its so called humanism which made her give up her dearest, though faulty, principles?

**chador* – A sheet of cloth wrapped like a shawl or used as a night sheet and is usually white in colour.



With these thoughts I escorted her to the car. For a few moments her breathlessness did not permit her to speak. Once her breath stabilized she spoke words for which I was entirely unprepared. She said, "From now onwards I will always travel by air, this is the most comfortable mode of travel."

That night while narrating the events of Panipat and Delhi she laid to rest all my other doubts. She said, "Neither are good, neither they nor us. They stopped at nothing, neither Muslims, nor Hindus, nor Sikhs. They all tasted blood. But as a Muslim I lay greater blame on Muslims, they have maligned Islam by their evil deeds."

Those days Bombay was in the grip of deadly rioting. Amma knew that Shivaji Park, where I stayed, was a Hindu locality, with no more than two or three Muslim homes. But the very next evening she wore her *burqa* and taking two of the children by their hand went to the beach to walk on the sand and collect seashells. I tried to gently dissuade her but she did not agree and said, "Arre, who will kill me?" She calmly kept strolling along the beach and I, worried sick, 'guarded' her while sitting on the boundary wall of my house. It turned out that I was the coward

and she was brave. And it was her faith in humanity which was vindicated rather than my doubts.

My friend, a Punjabi refugee was staying with me those days. When she heard that many Hindus of his hometown Shaikhupura had been murdered, his family had fled the killing fields, and had landed in a wretched state in some refugee camp, she cried for a long time. Then she took me aside and said. "Now listen to me. From this day on, this boy is your brother. You must always look after him. Perhaps this is one way in which we can atone for the sins our fellow Muslims have committed on the innocents." After her daily prayers she used to raise her hands in *dua**, "Allah may all homeless Hindus, Sikhs, Muslims return safely to their homes and in lieu of their safety may we return safely to our Panipat."

The day when the news of Gandhiji's assassination broke, it seemed like the news of the death of a dear family member. My mother did not eat that night. Next morning, she sat near the radio listening to the commentary of the funeral procession and last rites, with tears streaking her face. "What will become

**dua* - A prayer.

of India now?" she said now and then, with a deep sigh.

It was a cruel twist of fate that she who loved her country so much could not get a handful of its soil after death. She went to her younger daughter in Karachi and there her old disease took a dangerous turn. She did not survive. Till her last breath she remained faithful to her country. She knew that his political principles would not allow her son to visit Pakistan under the given circumstances. She also knew that if she wrote to him that in her last moments she wanted to see him, he would rush to her side despite his principled stand. So she died, having never once asked that I be called to her bedside. On the contrary, she gave instructions that no one was to write about her condition lest I set aside my principles to be by her side.



She herself wanted to return to India. The moment she felt better she sent me word. "Arrange for a permit, I want

to return." A few days before her death, the Indian High Commissioner, declaring her an Indian Citizen, issued her permission to return to India forever.

But she left the world, while dreaming of returning to India. She is buried in a *qabristan** in Karachi. But her spirit, her memories, her exemplary life has remained with us here. All her property was looted in Panipat but the legacy she has left for us is much more valuable than all that land, house, jewellery and other riches.

And six yards of land in Pakistan will forever remain India because on this land is buried a Bharat Mata.

**qabristan* – cemetery.



Read India

Pratham Books was set up in 2004, as part of the Read India movement, a nation-wide campaign to promote reading among children. Pratham Books is a not-for-profit organization that publishes quality books for children in multiple Indian languages. Our mission is to see "a book in every child's hand" and democratize the joy of reading. If you would like to contribute to our mission, please email us at info@prathambooks.org.



Khwaja Ahmad Abbas (7 June 1914 – 1 June 1987) was a journalist, film director and writer who wrote 74 books. His films *Saat Hindustani* and *Do Boond Paani* won awards for Best Feature Films on National Integration.

Syeda Hameed, is one of the trustees of the Khwaja Ahmad Abbas Memorial Trust and an ex-member of the Planning Commission of India. A well known author, and women and Muslim rights expert, she loves theatre and cinema, especially her uncle K.A.Abbas's movies.



Niloufer Wadia is an artist who has started illustrating seriously after spending 20 years in the field of advertising. She is keen to explore various media to communicate her thoughts and feelings.

Khwaja Ahmad Abbas was a man of many parts. Pioneering and prolific writer, script writer, film maker and columnist, his work remains as relevant and inspirational today as it was a century ago.

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